

Compassionate Curriculum Draft 0626

Introduction: A Practice of Hope

The Compassionate Curriculum is a participatory framework for learning, reflection, and collective growth, designed with and for people with lived experience of trauma or any form of structural harm. It draws on the idea that lived experience is a form of knowledge, and that healing, critical understanding, and imagination are all necessary for building more just futures.

Rather than asking participants simply to receive information, the curriculum invites them to shape meaning together. It is grounded in shared authorship, mutual aid, and an ethic of accountability. It is also strengths-based. The work does not begin from what people lack, but from what they already know, have survived, and can build together. Across the curriculum, participants are encouraged to reflect on their own experience, listen to one another, and practice forms of collective learning that can support both personal transformation and broader social change.

The curriculum has three connected sections. *Beloved Community* focuses on identity, belonging, emotional fluency, and historical trauma. It helps participants better understand themselves, their relationships, and the wider systems that shape how they move through the world. *Restorative Practice* introduces circles, active listening, reauthoring, and other tools that support trust, reflection, accountability, and shared responsibility. *Media, Narrative and Futuring* explores storytelling, representation, and imagination. It invites participants to examine dominant narratives, tell fuller stories about themselves, and build imaginative capacity for creative problem solving and future making.

The Compassionate Curriculum is designed as an open and living framework. It can be used in universities, community organizations, advocacy spaces, research settings, and other group contexts where facilitators want to support belonging, dialogue, and collaborative learning. Some groups may use it as a structured series of workshops. Others may draw on individual sections or activities and adapt them to local needs.

At its core, the curriculum is guided by participation, embodiment, storytelling, and multimodal learning. It aims to create conditions in which people can think critically, connect across differences, and imagine otherwise together. In this sense, the Compassionate Curriculum is not only a set of exercises, but a way of practicing mutual support, shared inquiry, and hope in common.

Beloved Community

CC Archive: Beloved Community

Overview

This section explores how people come to know themselves, find community, develop language for pain and healing, and better understand the historical trauma carried by others and by themselves. It is grounded in the idea that personal well being and collective liberation are deeply connected. The section begins with self reflection, then moves outward toward relationships, emotional fluency, and historical understanding.

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I. Identity: Helping to know ourselves

For Facilitators:

"Beloved community is formed not by the eradication of difference but by its affirmation, by each of us claiming the identities and cultural legacies that shape who we are and how we live in the world." (bell hooks)

Identity work should begin with self reflection. There are real differences between groups of people, and we are entitled to explore these. But we must start with ourselves because our identities impact others and our environment. Participants are more likely to engage thoughtfully with the identities of others if they have first considered their own. Encouraging reflective self-talk is essential for understanding ourselves and key to wellbeing. The goal is not to arrive at a fixed definition of self, but to recognize identity as layered, relational, and changing. This section may also be used to introduce intersectionality as a way of understanding how different aspects of identity interact, and how these interactions shape experience.

'Identity is such a fundamental part of being a successful human, it is often said that you cannot do anything until you know who you are. As social creatures, part of knowing who we are is knowing what group we belong to, what characteristics, values, or beliefs we share with others, which others and why' (Hirsch 2018:21).

'The key to wellbeing is to understand yourself and to take notice of your identity, as it has an enormous influence on our experiences' (Cousins 2019:41).

'The habit of checking in with yourself is a powerful vehicle for self-care and self –nurturing when society offers everyday complex challenges. As with any habit, it takes practice, perseverance, and patience to embed newly discovered awareness and follow this through into our daily lives; however, if you can begin to create opportunities for a positive identity you will be making an investment in your wellbeing and life satisfaction that is immeasurable' (Cousin 2019:41).

Activity 1: Developing intersectional mindfulness

Begin by discussing your own identity as a facilitator. Model openness, complexity, and self awareness. Then invite participants to reflect on questions from Susan Cousins (2019:41):

- How would you describe your identity?
- Who are you?
- What aspects of your identity feel most important to you?
- Who or what has shaped your understanding of yourself?
- Who or what has shaped your understanding of other identities?
- How do you feel about the identities you carry?
- How would you describe yourself racially, and how do you feel about that part of your identity?
- If you imagine moving through the world with a different racial or cultural identity, what might change? What might be lost? What, if anything, might feel different?

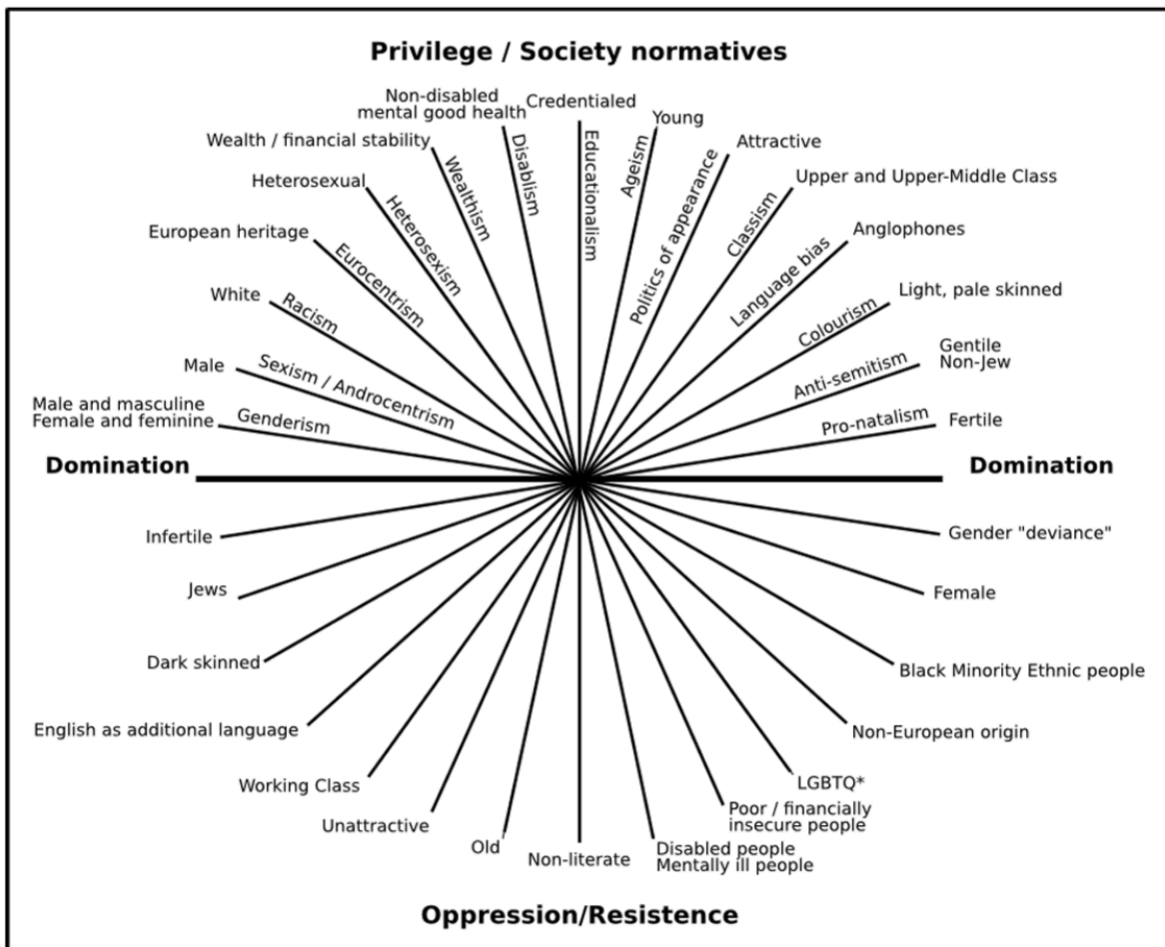
Activity 2: Intersectionality as practice

Introduce intersectionality as a way of understanding how systems of power affect lived experience. This can be supported through short video material, discussion, or diagrams that show how privilege and oppression can overlap.

- Professor Kimberle Crenshaw (2018) <https://youtu.be/ViDtnfQ9FHc> who coined the term intersectionality, which enables us to explore how experiences are affected by different competing identities and how these impact to exclude individuals in society (Bhopal, 2018:47).
- Tasneem Chopra (2023) 'The pursuit of intersectional feminism' https://youtu.be/h4Us1dCRfFI?si=LEeo4ufUhR_RCKjX

Possible discussion prompts:

- How do different parts of your identity affect each other?
- Where do you experience privilege?
- Where do you experience exclusion or discrimination?
- How does intersectionality help us understand our own lives and the lives of others?



Adapted from Kathryn Pauly Morgan (1996) "Describing the Emporaro's New Clothes: Three Myths of Education (In)Equality." in *The Gender Question in Education: Theory, Pedagogy & Politics*, Ann Diller et al., Boulder, CO: Westview.

For Facilitators:

For further critique, consider this diagram of the intersecting axis of privilege, domination and oppression from Kathryn Pauly Morgan (1996), that helps explain how people are positioned differently in relation to power. We all exist on an axis of oppression & domination as demonstrated here. Some positions come with greater access, recognition, and advantage, while others are shaped by discrimination and exclusion. These positions are not fixed—our identities intersect and shift across different contexts, creating complex, layered experiences. Understanding this helps us become more aware of both our own position and the unequal conditions others may be navigating.

Activity 3: Nature of Bias

Introduce the idea that everyone has bias, including unconscious bias and affinity bias. Invite participants to reflect on how people are often drawn toward those who feel familiar, and how this affects perception and behavior.

Watch the video by Dr Jennifer Eberhardt for insights on unconscious bias from her book, *Biased: Uncovering the hidden prejudice that shapes what we see, think and do*.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-ri1IFCqGjQ>

Potential prompts:

- What kinds of bias do you see in everyday life?
- How do bias and stereotypes flatten people into a single story?
- What are the risks of allowing one story to stand in for a whole group?

Background

Unconscious bias is simply our unintentional people's preferences. Bias is often decided in less than one tenth of a second, many times faster than we can process an image. People often associate bias with racial bias, though bias takes many forms. An affinity bias means we prefer those who are like us. It makes us feel warm and fuzzy when we have people to reconfirm our thoughts, fears and background. We also prefer those who have the same education, career background, accent (scouserssss stand up), ethnicity etc. For example, I might have an affinity bias for anyone who supports Arsenal, and this makes me believe they are a good and somehow better person than any Manchester United fan. If you have a brain you have bias.

Activity 4: Social Identity Wheel



Based on the social identity wheel, participants map out their identities and consider the questions below.

- Which identities do you think about most often?
- Which identities do you think about least often?
- Which of your own identities would you like to learn more about?
- Which identities have the strongest effect on how you perceive yourself?
- Which identities have the strongest effect on how others perceive you?

Alt version:

Download a blank version and have the group create their own wheel for discussion. More [information here from MIT Open Learning Library](#).

II. Finding your people

Overview

This section focuses on community, belonging, and the power of relationships. It asks how people find support, build trust, and create forms of collective care. It is especially grounded in traditions of collectivism, mutual support, and radical healing.

This is about understanding all the systems of oppression that impact our wellness. A remedy to this is finding your crew, your people. Black women have always built collectives, from the Combahee River Collective to the Liverpool Black Sisters to The Goddess Projects. Therefore, we encourage you to figure out ways to survive, laugh, love, and heal in ways that are connected to people, as there is power in people.

For Facilitators

Frame this section around the idea that the self does not stand alone. Encourage participants to think about community not only as something they belong to, but as something they help create. Community may be built through shared identity, shared experience, shared values, or shared effort.

Activity 1: Community in practice

Invite participants to reflect on examples of community building, especially those rooted in mutual support, collective care, and grassroots organizing. Watch these two videos:

- Nikotris Perkins (2019), an urban studies doctoral student who presented a talk on Black women and community: <https://youtu.be/e78v42tz4eY?si=YoRgVMD0hnRme4hr>
- Doug Shipman, TEDX Atlanta, <https://youtu.be/cP5PAul3H4E?si=Jvkfy5LguMnPyTQN>

Potential prompts:

- Who are you in community with?
- What does community mean to you?
- What can we learn from existing collectives and support networks?
- How do we make friends? How do we engage with other communities?
- Can we make beloved community together?
- How do we begin to build community across difference?

Activity 2: Finding your squad!

Participants should identify and map who is in their support network, their squad.

Potential prompts:

- Who is already in your squad?
- Who are your key people? What qualities do they have?
- Who is missing?
- What communities or groups might you need to join?
- What makes it hard to reach out?
- What qualities might you need to cultivate to find your people?

III. Developing your language: finding words to articulate pain, trauma, and healing

Overview

This section focuses on emotional fluency: the ability to notice, name, understand, and work with emotion. It supports participants in developing language for what they feel, where they feel it, and how emotions shape relationships, leadership, and healing.

For Facilitators

This section may be especially meaningful for participants who have been discouraged from expressing vulnerability, or who have been taught that certain emotions are unacceptable. Encourage participants to approach emotions without shame. The goal is not to eliminate difficult feelings, but to coexist with them more consciously and compassionately.

Background

Emotional Fluency describes the relationships we have with our emotions. It allows us to listen more effectively and respond appropriately during tense conversations, recognising what others might be feeling and if they are reaching out to connect. In the workplace, it's important

to acknowledge and embrace emotions. Historically, male-dominated work environments have selectively acknowledged the value of emotions and who is entitled to express them.

Being aware of our emotions allows us to start understanding where they come from and what thoughts trigger them. Developing emotional fluency goes beyond just recognizing and labelling our emotions - it means learning to coexist with them without feeling the need to push them away. To be emotionally fluent, we need to be present enough to notice and name our judgments so that we can start peacefully coexisting with however we feel. Our beloved communities help us discuss and co-exist with our intersectional, lived experiences.

Activity 1: Emotional fluency

Introduce emotional fluency as the ability to sense, name, and work with emotions in a healthy and productive way.

Key ideas:

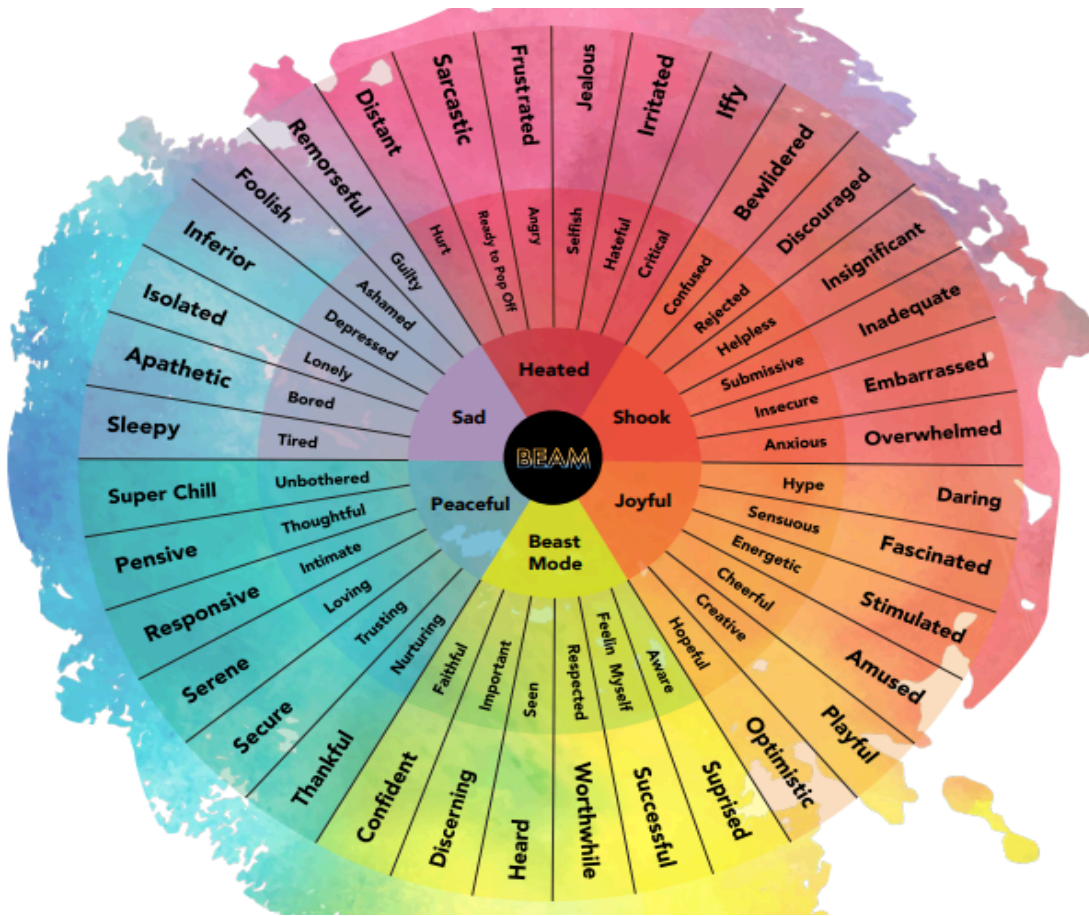
- Emotions are not problems in themselves
- Judgment, shame, and suppression often make emotions harder to live with
- Naming emotions can help people move from reactivity to reflection
- Emotional fluency supports trust, empathy, and leadership

Potential prompts:

- What emotions do you find easy to name?
- Which emotions feel harder to acknowledge?
- Where did you learn which emotions are acceptable or unacceptable?
- How do your emotions show up in your body?
- Can you name the emotions you are experiencing now?
- What do these emotions feel like? Describe where and what you are feeling, and how this state of mind is unfolding throughout your body without judgement. E.g My chest is tight. My legs are restless.
- Work down your body from head to toe, and be factual about where you feel the emotion, is it in your scalp, your brow, eyebrows, ear lobes, cheeks, jaw? Reassure yourself that everything is okay and that you are safe.

Negative emotions often engage the primal brain. We need to engage the thinking brain, and labelling what you feel helps to do that. It also helps us focus on what we can control. For example, if my jaw is clenched, I need to relax it, and I need to breathe more slowly and deeply.

Activity 2: Emotional Wheel



Consider this emotion wheel developed by the Black Emotional and Mental Health Collective, an organization which aims to dismantle systemic barriers to mental health support through peer-led training programs. On your own or with a partner:

- Make a list of the emotions you often feel and the physical sensations you feel in association with them.
- Which emotions feel familiar?
- Which emotions do you resist?
- Where do you feel certain emotions in your body?
- What judgments do you attach to certain feelings?
- How do these judgments affect your relationships and empathy?

IV. Understanding historical trauma of others; racial, gender, sexuality & socio-economic identities.

Overview

This section introduces historical trauma as a collective and intergenerational form of harm shaped by colonization, racism, violence, and systemic oppression. It asks participants to reflect on how trauma is transmitted, how it shapes present life, and how greater awareness can support empathy and healing.

For Facilitators

Historical trauma can be difficult and activating material. Go slowly. Encourage reflection, care, and grounded discussion. Participants may carry both personal and inherited trauma, and may respond in different ways. Make space for complexity.

Background

Trauma may be a significant one-off event or the consequence of ongoing insidious actions, microaggressions, or being constantly treated differently.

Hartmann and Gone (2014) describe historical trauma as differing from common lifetime psychological trauma in four keyways: it is colonial in origin, collective in impact, cumulative across adverse events, and cross-generational in transmission of risk and vulnerability.

Historical trauma consists of psychological and emotional injuries shared collectively across generations resulting from past collective traumatic experiences or events, manifesting in perceived discrimination and oppression, learned mistrust, exhaustion and feelings of humiliation, cultural-related syndromes, and historical thoughts of loss, associated with various clinical psychological disorders and risk behaviours within a group that share a similar social, historical, and political background. (Mutuyimana, C., & Maercker, A. (2023)

Examples include the experiences of First Nation people in North America, Aboriginal Australians and anti-Black racism amongst the African diaspora.

The imprints of historical trauma are often deeply ingrained, and many people may not even be aware of its presence (Maté, 2022). This can lead to negative emotions and physical ill health, including psychosomatic illness. Historical intergenerational trauma is often intensified by day-to-day acute chronic stress, resulting in damaging physical and emotional consequences.

Activity 1: How Do People Experience Historical Trauma?

1. Watch the video *How Do People Experience Historical Trauma*:
<https://youtu.be/sjJUQlodh0g?si=aYfHpmAUlsZGZYsq>

In pairs, discuss the following questions:

- What examples of historical trauma do you know about?

- How does learning about historical trauma affect the way you think about race, identity, and culture?
- How is historical trauma carried into the present?
- What is the relationship between historical trauma and microaggressions?
- How can cultural celebration and community support help counter harm?
- How can you encourage and support cultural celebration?

2. Watch Dr Gabor Mate, video https://youtu.be/ak_nLWQ8EtY?si=EJKs36lEDheQXtdw#

- Discuss trauma and how it affects the authentic self

Activity 2: Practice self-reflection

- What aspects of your life do you feel good about? (positive attributes/strengths)
- What aspects of your life fill you up? (spaces in which you feel enriched)
- How are the effects of historical or direct trauma showing up in you? (Identify vulnerabilities).
- What are you doing to overcome your personal/historical or direct trauma?

**Active listening” YouTube video: https://youtu.be/Qg8PIK74KO4?si=luRH_0C_K4Ji2xel

Activity 3: Grounding Exercise

Practise letting go of the past and being open to receive:

Breath in, stepping forward with one foot and turn your palms downward;

Breath out, lifting your arms up to horizontal position, letting go of all tension and negativity.

Breath in, turning palms upward and drawing them back in towards the chest, breathing in peace and healing.

Repeat with the other foot forward. Breathe out pain. Breath in calm and the opportunity to heal.

Closing discussion

This section may conclude with reflection on racial trauma, intergenerational survival strategies, and the need for community, justice, and institutional change.

Background

Dr. Shelley Harrell's six-level framework helps describe the physical and emotional effects that can follow exposure to racism. These harms are reflected in broader patterns of inequality: the Race Disparity Audit (2017) found that Black and Brown people in the UK are more likely to be admitted to psychiatric hospitals, more likely to be sectioned under the Mental Health Act, and more likely to receive poorer care and worse outcomes. Despite this evidence, there has been limited sustained effort to reduce racial inequalities in mental health or reform the institutions that reproduce them.

Harrell's framework shows that racial trauma operates at multiple levels. These include racism-related life events, such as racist abuse or assault; vicarious racism, or indirect exposure through hearing about or witnessing racism; and daily racist micro-stressors, the subtle but repeated acts often referred to as microaggressions. It also includes chronic contextual stressors, such as living with the constant awareness of racial inequality and the unequal distribution of resources; collective experiences of racism, in which violence against one's racial group is witnessed and felt communally; and transgenerational transmission of trauma, in which survival strategies and the effects of oppression are passed across generations.

The final three levels in particular help explain the group-based and cumulative nature of racial trauma, which is often overlooked. They show why events such as the deaths of Stephen Lawrence, Anthony Walker, George Floyd, Tamir Rice, and Alton Sterling resonate so deeply across communities, and why anti-racist movements remain necessary. Harrell's framework makes visible the chronic, layered, and collective harms of racism, while also helping distinguish racial trauma from more individualized accounts of trauma.

Restorative Practice

CC Archive: Restorative Practices

Overview

This section introduces restorative practice as a participatory and relational mode of learning. It centers oral storytelling, listening, shared authorship, and collective responsibility. The practices in this section help participants build trust, reflect on experience, and develop more compassionate ways of being together.

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Intro

Restorative practices activate oral storytelling within a participatory, non-hierarchical process. They help participants draw on lived experience as a source of knowledge, connection, and collective vision. Story sharing builds rapport and trust, while laying the groundwork for the idea that participants can foster positive transformation in others through a critical understanding of their own experience. Restorative practices also help shift learning away from expert-driven models and toward shared authorship. Participants are not asked simply to receive information, but to shape meaning together. In this sense, circles are both a pedagogical structure and a relational practice.

Restorative practices may operate within both restorative justice and transformative justice frameworks. At the center of both is the question: how do we define justice? A useful tension to hold is: Punishment $\longleftrightarrow$ Repair. The five Rs of restorative justice are: Relationship, Respect, Responsibility, Repair and Reintegration. This section can be used to support discussion of how circles relate both to interpersonal repair and to broader structural transformation.

Jean Stevenson, Cree of Peguis First Nation, Manitoba, in *The Circle of Healing*, names the tension that exists when non-Indigenous practitioners adapt healing circles without sustained accountability to the Indigenous communities, particularly from the Americas, from which such practices emerge. The need for Indigenous leadership and guidance in these processes is

critical. We use circles, a central restorative justice process, with gratitude and with full acknowledgment of the leadership of Indigenous communities in our own training and ongoing learning of this practice and way of life.

In many educational settings, the word facilitator implies a power differential in which one person guides and others receive. In restorative practice, and especially in circle work, that role shifts. The facilitator becomes a circlekeeper: someone responsible for the integrity of the process while also participating in it with honesty and care.

The circlekeeper is not the expert whose job is to provide solutions. Solutions are built collectively. The circlekeeper helps establish a respectful, brave, and safer space. At the same time, circlekeepers do hold a particular kind of power: they shape openings and closings, frame questions, and guide the rhythm of the circle. An effective circlekeeper remains aware of that power, reflects on their own bias, and works to use structure in service of collective learning rather than control.

Ideally, circles are supported by at least two circlekeepers, seated across from one another. This allows one person to track the overall process while the other supports documentation, transitions, or follow-up as needed.

For Facilitators

Circlekeeping requires preparation, trust in process, and careful listening. In general, circlekeepers should:

- rely on open-ended questions
- pre-work to ensure emotional safety, establish a shared purpose, and anticipate potential conflicts
- listen to understand rather than to direct
- participate in prompts alongside others
- remain attentive to their own feelings and judgments
- honor both individual and collective boundaries

This section works toward what Arao and Clemens name ‘brave spaces,’ where participants identify what they need in order to participate authentically, and where mutual care is shared.

Activity: Preparation Before the Circle

Before a circle occurs there are processes that prepare all participants, including the circlekeepers/facilitators - for the process. The stages of pre-work are:

Stage 1: Assessment and Intake (The "Why" and "Who")

Elements include:

- Meeting individually with participants—especially in conflict or high-stakes settings—to assess readiness, explain the process, and manage expectations.
- Defining the duties and responsibilities for the co-facilitators
 - Meeting with your co-leader to assign roles, map out who opens/closes, decide how to hand off leadership, and create an invisible signal if someone needs to pause the room).
- Mapping the stakeholder context
 - This could include the group's hidden history, including recent organizational changes, unspoken tensions, or cultural dynamics that might affect participation.

Stage 2: Design and Prompt Engineering (The Curriculum)

Elements include:

- The Sequential Arc Script: Map out the timeline on paper to ensure the group is not rushed into deep vulnerability too quickly.
 - *Example:* Allocating 10 minutes for an introductory check-in, 15 minutes for community-building, 30 minutes for the core deep prompt, and 10 minutes for the closing reflection.
- Drafting "Powerful Questions": Crafting open-ended, storytelling prompts that encourage reflection rather than defensive reactions or quick intellectual answers.
 - Development of the Circle questions including grounding activities, circle round questions, closing, and any other prompts.
- Community Agreements: Drafting a baseline list of community agreements to present to the room for collective editing and consensus. This list should be informed by Stage 1.
 - *Example:* Have the classic four pillars of circle keeping on a flipchart: 1) *Speak from the heart*, 2) *Listen from the heart*, 3) *Speak with relevance*, 4) *Bring spontaneous, lean expression*.

Stage 3: Physical Environment Setup (The Space)

Elements include:

- Space assessment
 - When and where logistics, how will the circle 'sit' in the space
 - What are the circle elements that will be used, including the mantle and talking pieces

Stage 4: Facilitator Self-Regulation (The Internal Prep)

Elements include:

- Bias and Trigger Tracking: Pausing to clear your mind of personal assumptions regarding the incoming participants.
 - *Example:* Imagining the circle process with each of the persons who will be participating. If you have time, journaling about your feelings, naming them without judgment and creating action plans to address the biases and/or triggers identified.

- The Grounding Routine: Engaging in physical and mental decompression to ensure you do not absorb or mirror the nervous energy of the room.
 - Example: Grounding breathing techniques in the space where the circle will occur.

Activity: Entering the Circle

Overview

This activity introduces participants to restorative practice and the basic elements of circle work.

For Facilitators

Circles are the primary restorative practice used in this curriculum. As Kay Pranis and Carolyn Boyes-Watson describe in *Circle Forward*, they work best when groups begin by getting acquainted, establishing shared values, and building trust before moving into deeper discussion. Circles may be used for many purposes, including healing, grieving, support, resolving conflict, reintegration, and celebration.

A *talking piece* is an object passed around the circle that marks who is speaking and reminds others to listen actively; it also allows any participant to pass. A *mantle* is a cloth or central space where meaningful objects may be placed to help mark the circle as intentional and distinct. A *land acknowledgement* is one way of naming the histories, peoples, and ongoing legacies that shape the place where a circle is taking place. Each of these is introduced in practice below.

Set up the room in a circle if possible, with enough space between shares so that participants can see one another clearly. Be attentive to accessibility needs in advance. Keep paper and pen nearby for notes or follow-up observations, and have a large sheet of paper or easel ready if you plan to record community agreements.

A circle will usually move through the following sequence:

- welcome and purpose
- opening or icebreaker and where appropriate, land acknowledgement
- community agreements
- check-in
- discussion rounds

- check-out and closing

Welcome and purpose:

- the circlekeeper introduces themselves & the talking piece;
- if participants are new to restorative practice, the circlekeeper explains their role and how the talking piece is used;
- if using a mantle, explain what it is and why the objects matter.

Opening and Icebreaker

Begin with a simple introductory question to help participants enter the space and process.

Some questions might require more trust and openness, so not all will be appropriate for every group. Examples here, and more in [Circle Questions](#) below:

- If you could have one superpower, what would it be?
- Who are your heroes and why?
- One goal for your time in this workshop is...
- One thing you would not know about me just by seeing me is...
- One aspect of my identity that feels important to bring into the circle is...

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- The circlekeeper, holding the talking piece, invites participants to name what they need in order to feel able to speak openly and honestly in the circle.
- Example prompt: What agreements are important to you to ensure that you personally will feel braver in speaking openly and honestly in this circle?
- The talking piece is passed to the left, so that each participant has the opportunity to add, or pass.
- Record responses and revisit them as needed. Some circlekeepers may invite participants to sign the final agreements.

This process helps strengthen consensus-based decision making. The agreements may take time to develop across multiple rounds. They should also be revisited over time.

Check-in

After the welcome and agreements, do a simple check-in round connected to the day's theme. Examples might be, "how are you today, on a scale of 1–10, and why?"

Discussion rounds

- Should only happen after participants have checked in, understand the purpose of the circle, and have known who is present.
- Questions should be open-ended, intentional, and connected to personal experience. These prompts focus on the core objective of the session, encouraging participants to

unpack complex topics, share personal stories, and engage in reflective problem-solving.

- Always check in after a round and pass the talking piece again in case anyone who initially passed wishes to speak.
- Some examples here, and more can be found in [Circle Questions](#) below.
 - Who do you think has been affected by this situation, and in what specific ways have they been impacted?
 - What has been the hardest part of this experience for you personally?
 - What needs to happen right now to make things as right as possible for everyone involved?
 - What concerns are you holding right now regarding our upcoming shift? What are your fears?
 - What is one practical resource or support you need to successfully navigate this change?
 - What is a unique aspect of your cultural heritage that significantly shapes how you show up to this work every day?
 - What is one intentional step we can take as a collective to ensure every person in this room feels heard and valued?
 - What is a collective lesson we have learned about ourselves as a group?
 - How can we better look out for one another's well-being?

Closing

Close with a round of responses to reflective prompts that helps participants leave the circle with care and intention. Potential prompts:

- What are you taking with you from today?
- How will you practice self-care today?
- What is a commitment you are willing to make today based on our circle today?

After the closing round, the circlekeeper may guide a brief grounding exercise such as breathing, movement, a poem, a song, or a call and response.

Optional follow-up: Talking Pieces

After the second circle, once participants have become more familiar with one another, the circle keeper may invite them to bring an object of personal significance to serve as a talking piece and, if they wish, share why it is meaningful to them. In digital circles, the talking piece and mantle may be symbolic rather than physical, but the same principles still apply.

Activity: Sharing Our Stories

Overview

This activity can begin as journaling, either in or between sessions, and later move into circle sharing. The task is to write “your story.”

Prompts:

- What is your name?
- Where do you live? Did you always live there?
- Where did you grow up?
- What childhood memories stay with you?
- Who do you live with?
- Do you have siblings? What is your relationship with them?
- What is your relationship like with your parents or guardians?
- What hardships have you faced? What obstacles have you overcome?
- What accomplishments are you proud of?
- How did you come to this work?
- Why is this work important to you?
- How will you activate what you are learning?
- What are your passions and long-term goals?

For Facilitators

Depending on group size, this activity may unfold across several sessions. It can help if one of the circlekeepers shares first to model the activity, or if a few participants are prepared in advance, to see if they might be comfortable sharing early on. Participants should always have the option to pass.

Allow breaks between stories. These circles can be intense, and pauses help the group remain present for one another.

Activity: Reauthoring Circles

Overview

Reauthoring is a way of understanding how the stories we tell about ourselves are shaped by larger social forces, including institutions, culture, and systems of power. The term was first developed by Michael White and David Epston (1990) as part of Narrative Therapy. In this curriculum, reauthoring is not therapy. It is a community practice that helps people reflect on how dominant myths about race, class, gender, disability, criminalization, and belonging shape identity, and how those myths might be challenged.

Reauthoring asks us to look closely at the stories that get repeated about who people are, who belongs, and whose knowledge matters. This is especially important in higher education, research, and advocacy spaces, where institutions often produce their own narratives about credibility, worth, and inclusion.

Reauthoring practice looks for what are sometimes called problem-saturated narratives: stories in which a person becomes defined by hardship, stigma, or a single experience. For people who have been criminalized, these stories can become internalized as fixed identities, obscuring what it took to survive, what was learned through experience, what values matter, and what strengths are already present.

Reauthoring asks: what else is true? What strengths, values, knowledge, and insight are already present alongside hardship, stigma, or a single defining story? It refuses the single story and makes space for a fuller account.

A reauthoring circle is a structured conversation with three roles:

- storyteller: one person shares a story, challenge, or question
- witnesses: the group listens and reflects back strengths, values, and possibilities
- circlekeeper: the person who holds the structure and supports the process

The goal is not to judge, fix, or give advice. It is to listen together for what matters, what has been survived, and what has been learned.

For Facilitators

Before beginning, the circlekeeper asks for a volunteer storyteller willing to share a challenge, question, or moment of growth, and checks in with them to ensure consent.

Introduce the process clearly:

- one person will share
- others will listen and reflect back what they hear
- the group listens for strength and for what matters
- no advice is given

The circlekeeper should describe the process of witnessing, and the importance of good questions in reauthoring. A good question can interrupt a dominant narrative and help someone see themselves differently.

Examples of good questions:

- What did you notice about yourself at that moment?

- What does this tell you about what matters to you?
- What did it take to get through that?
- What did you need at that time?
- What might help you think about this differently?

Witnessing means to listen for resilience, recognize knowledge and capacity, and reflect these back. The goal is not to fix, but to name what is already present. Examples of witnessing:

- What I'm hearing is that you...
- You kept going despite...
- I'm noticing the strategies you developed to cope with that ...
- It seems like care, dignity, or fairness really matter to you
- I'm hearing a deep commitment to...
- You've learned something important through that experience
- What I'm hearing is a story about how you cared, resisted, or learned along the way

Process

- The circlekeeper convenes the opening of the circle.
- The storyteller shares while holding the talking piece.
- The group pauses.
- The talking piece is passed around the circle. Witnesses reflect on what they heard.
- When the talking piece returns to the storyteller, invite reflection:
 - What did you hear?
 - What felt true?
 - What surprised you?
 - What do you want to carry forward?

Closing reflection:

- What stood out to you?
- What felt possible in this process?
- Where might you use this in your own work?
- What support would help you feel more confident facilitating it?

Activity: Land & Ancestor Acknowledgement

Overview

This activity invites participants to reflect on the histories, places, ancestors, and lineages that shape the space they are in. It is based on Native Land Digital's resources to move beyond performative or transactional frameworks.

For Facilitators

Before facilitating this activity, research whose land the circle is taking place on, who lived there in the past, and who lives there now. This may require formal research as well as conversations with community members.

This can be a difficult activity. Participants may be adopted, may not know their histories, or may carry trauma related to family, slavery, colonization, migration, or displacement. Go slowly. Build in pauses.

In the Americas, where circles were first developed as a restorative practice, land acknowledgements are one way of naming the ongoing violence of colonialism and imperialism. In other parts of the world, this activity may need to be adapted, but the larger question remains: what histories of displacement, violence, survival, and resistance shape this place?

Potential prompts

- Who are the ancestors and people we should appreciate as we gather?
- What is your migration story?
- Who are your elders, living and transitioned, and how are they present in you?

Follow up options

- write your own land acknowledgement
- share it in circle
- develop a collective acknowledgement in small groups or as a whole group

Example from the Lenapehoking (NJ, eastern PA, southeastern NY):

“I want to begin with an acknowledgement that we are on the unceded territory of the Lenape people. I would like to acknowledge and pay my respects to the Lenape ancestors and to present and future generations on this homeland, as well as throughout the Lenape diaspora. I would also like to extend this acknowledgement to all Indigenous peoples who now and in the future call these Lenape homelands, Lenapehoking, home. This acknowledgement is a commitment to addressing the ongoing legacies of settler colonialism, racism, mass incarceration, and the prison industrial complex.”

Circle Questions and Listening Practices

Source material includes *Mediators Beyond Borders* and *The Art of Powerful Questions* by Eric E. Vogt, Juanita Brown, and David Isaacs.

In the Circle practice, questions are called prompts and are sequenced carefully moving from low-vulnerability questions (to build safety) to high-vulnerability questions (to address the core topic), and finish with reflection.

Prompt development then is informed by the stage of the process. For example:

1. Check-In & Icebreaker Rounds (Low Vulnerability)

Used at the start to get every voice in the room used to speaking without pressure.

2. Community & Relationship Building Rounds (Medium Vulnerability)

Used to discover shared values, foster empathy, and deepen connections between participants.

3. Core Topic & Reflection Rounds (High Vulnerability)

Used to dive into the main purpose of the circle, whether exploring a problem, processing a change, or resolving a conflict.

4. Check-Out & Closing Rounds (Low Vulnerability)

Used to ground the group, capture takeaways, and safely transition participants back into their day.

Quick Facilitator Tips for Round Questions

- Keep them open-ended: Avoid questions that can be answered with a simple "yes" or "no". Use *What*, *How*, or *Can you describe...* instead of *Why* (which can make people defensive).
- Model the prompt: As the facilitator, it is often helpful to answer the question first when you introduce it to demonstrate the depth of vulnerability you are inviting.
- Pass is always an option: Remind participants that when the talking piece comes to them, they can choose to pass, hold it in silence for a moment, or speak.

Examples of Circle Questions:

Opening questions

Please say your name and...

- share something you hope to experience or learn while you are here
- share something that would make you glad you chose to participate
- say what draws you to this inquiry
- name something you left behind in order to be here today

Deeper opening

- Would you be willing to share something from your life experience that shaped your perspective on the need for this type of compassionate curriculum?

Deepening questions

- What is at the heart of this issue for you?
- What hopes, fears, concerns, or unmet needs are present for you around this issue?

- What dilemmas or opportunities do you see?

Processing questions

- What is taking shape here?
- What are you hearing underneath the variety of opinions being expressed?
- What had real meaning for you in what you heard?
- Is there anything we are not seeing clearly?

Forward-moving questions

- What could happen that would help you feel fully engaged in this work?
- What is possible here, and who cares?
- What next steps would you like to take, individually or collectively?
- How can we support one another in taking those steps?
- What seed might we plant together that could make the most difference for the future of this situation?

Closing questions

- What are you taking with you from this circle?
- What did you contribute, or wish you had contributed?
- What next steps do you hope to take?
- What questions do you hope this group addresses next?
- What support do you need, or wish to offer, as you leave?

Skills for active listening

- Body language: maintain open body language and attention. Maintain eye contact where appropriate, face the speaker, adopt a relaxed posture, and avoid multitasking.
- Following: allow the speaker space to speak without interruption. This means reducing unnecessary questions, allowing silence, and letting a thought unfold.
- Paraphrasing and reflecting: summarize what you heard, including both content and feeling. For example: "What I'm hearing is..."
- Ask open-ended questions: that invite reflection rather than yes/no answers.
- Validation: assume that whatever is being shared however clearly or imperfectly, comes from something real in the speaker's experience.

Media, Narrative, Futuring

CC Archive: Media, Narrative and Futuring

Overview

This section supports participants in telling fuller stories about themselves, analyzing the stories told by the media, and building imaginative capacity for future making. It begins with individual reflection, moves through embodied storytelling and visual analysis, and ends with participatory futuring.

Table of Contents

- Notes for Facilitators
- [Exercises: Individual Reflection, Self-Portrait](#)
- [Exercises: Embodied Storytelling](#)
- [Exercises: Media Analysis & Visual Storytelling](#)
- [Exercises: Participatory Futuring and Worldbuilding](#)

Notes for Facilitators

How might lack of resources, cultural marginalization and the experience of trauma forestall the ability or willingness to imagine, or belief in the relevance of imagination itself?

This section begins from the understanding that dominant culture often flattens identity. People who are criminalized or stereotyped may begin to describe themselves through limiting narratives rather than through the full complexity of their lives, i.e. a young Black man who is arrested is compressed to "criminal." If people describe themselves from this constrained space, rather than telling their story as an individual, they are deprived of their distinct subjectivity.

Imagination is a practice of hope. It involves rearranging present ideas into new possible combinations. For people whose experience of choice has been limited, it may understandably be difficult to hope that any kind of future agency might be possible. Facilitators should avoid immediately confronting people who have had limited choice with an immediate request to imagine potential positive futures. It is often more effective to begin with low stakes forms of reflection and storytelling, then build gradually toward media analysis and futuring.

This work should be guided by clear values:

- Center lived experience of participants from historically marginalized groups. Support and care required to facilitate such participants scales up to support all participants.
- Ensure that all participants gain something from the process; the group as a whole should have a say in co-determining issues being discussed and means of disseminating any outcomes.

- Make clear how imagination connects to present action - as a mechanism to inform designs & systems the group might build, or ways the group might work together, in the present, to point toward a more positive future.
- Support storytelling through multiple forms and modalities
- Allow for play, experimentation, and gradual confidence building

This section begins by supporting participants in telling their own stories through multiple means, enabling them to describe life events in ways not constrained by systems of oppression. This work draws on different imagination-based methods, each directed toward distinct ends: to better understand how harmful cultural narratives are constructed and maintained; to experiment with reframing one's story from multiple perspectives; and to translate these stories through varied aesthetic forms that prompt reflection and dialogue.

Play matters here both as a loose, exploratory space and as a way of putting new ideas into motion. The activities in this section are designed to move from individual reflection to collective imagination in stages. This begins with individual reflection and different modes of storytelling, followed by media analysis, and finally individual and collective futuring.

Individual Reflection, Self Portrait

Overview

These exercises help participants reflect on identity, memory, mood, and self description through color, sound, writing, and image.

Contents:

Color Wheels

Color Field Portraits

Life in 3 Songs

I Am From poems

Writing prompts

Activity: Color Wheel

- Invite participants to look at the image of a color wheel, or picture one in their mind's eye and describe associations they have with each color. Associations might relate to an emotion, a memory, or a story they would like to tell.
- Optional: on a large piece of paper or white board, create a shared color wheel or color map that participants feel represents the entire group. This might involve shape, form, colors of choice, or written language as desired.

Activity: Color Field Portrait (after Mark Rothko)

- Create a self portrait using a stack of 2-3 color fields.

- Participants may reflect on different ways to create the stack, and share their design choices with a partner.
- For example, are the color fields framed within a larger background of a different color? Are there spaces in between the fields, and if so, how large?

Facilitators note:

You may wish to show Mark Rothko's Color Field paintings, either before or after the exercise, as part of the discussion.

Activity: Life in 3 Songs

- Invite participants to consider 3 songs that describe their life.
- Play each song, taking 1-2 minutes before or after each to explain its significance.
- Create and share the playlist.
- With consent, record each intro, followed by the song.

Activity: I Am From Poem

- Use George Ella Lyon's "I Am From" format to help participants translate memory and everyday detail into poetic form; copy onto blank sheets of paper as needed.
<http://www.georgeellalyon.com/where.html>
- Share out and, if given consent, record people reading aloud.
- Consider how the poems might lead to further writing; ie, mentions of a place might lead to writing about the memory of an event that happened there; mentions of music or food could lead to writing about people, places or events associated with those things.

Embodied Storytelling

Overview

These exercises translate personal experience into gesture, tableau, voice, and image. They allow participants to explore emotional memory and shared interpretation without requiring full disclosure.

Contents

- Story swap / Image theater
- Internal monologue
- Three-act future story (sensory triptych)

Activity: Story Swap > Image Theater (after Augusto Boal)

- In pairs, participants describe a scene or event from their life as if it was frozen in time, that they remember based on an emotional prompt.
- Potential prompts include: obstacle, hope, escape, isolation, finding silence.

- Describe everything possible based on sensory recall: What season was it, and what time of day? If outside, what were the surrounding buildings or landscape like? If inside, what was the interior like? What did things sound and smell like? What were the colors and light like?
- Describe relationships: was anyone else there? If so, who were they, how were they related to you and what was happening?
- The listener considers what they think to be the heart of the story, its emotional or conceptual core.
- With consent from their partner, the listener represents the story with a single frozen gesture.
- Other participants discuss what they see. If the storyteller chooses, they can disclose details of the original story.

Activity: Internal monologue

- Based on the previous exercise, the storyteller positions others in a tableau (a group of people standing in “freeze frame”), to represent the core moment of the story.
- The Teller gives participants the minimum contextual information necessary to understand where and who they are, i.e.: “We’re outside, in a city, in 1992. You’re a man around 35 yrs old.”
- Each participant imagines what their character is thinking, and one at a time, voices that internal monologue.
- Optional documentation, with consent:
 - Photograph participants in tableau;
 - Record audio of the voices;
 - Video walking around the group as participants voice their monologue.

Activity: Three-act future story (sensory triptych)

- Invite participants to imagine themselves moving through a future space they’d like to inhabit.
- Participants should describe critical sensory details of sight, sound, smell, touch and what their body feels like as it moves in relation to the space.
- Participants create three images that represent three key parts of the story, such as a beginning, middle and end, 3 different sensory perceptions, 3 emotions etc.

- Participants observe each other's images and describe their own associations with the imagery.
- This activity can be combined with Image Theater, Photovoice or Participatory Futuring exercises.



An example of the Three-Act Future storytelling exercise by Lorraine Cruz.

Media Analysis & Visual Storytelling

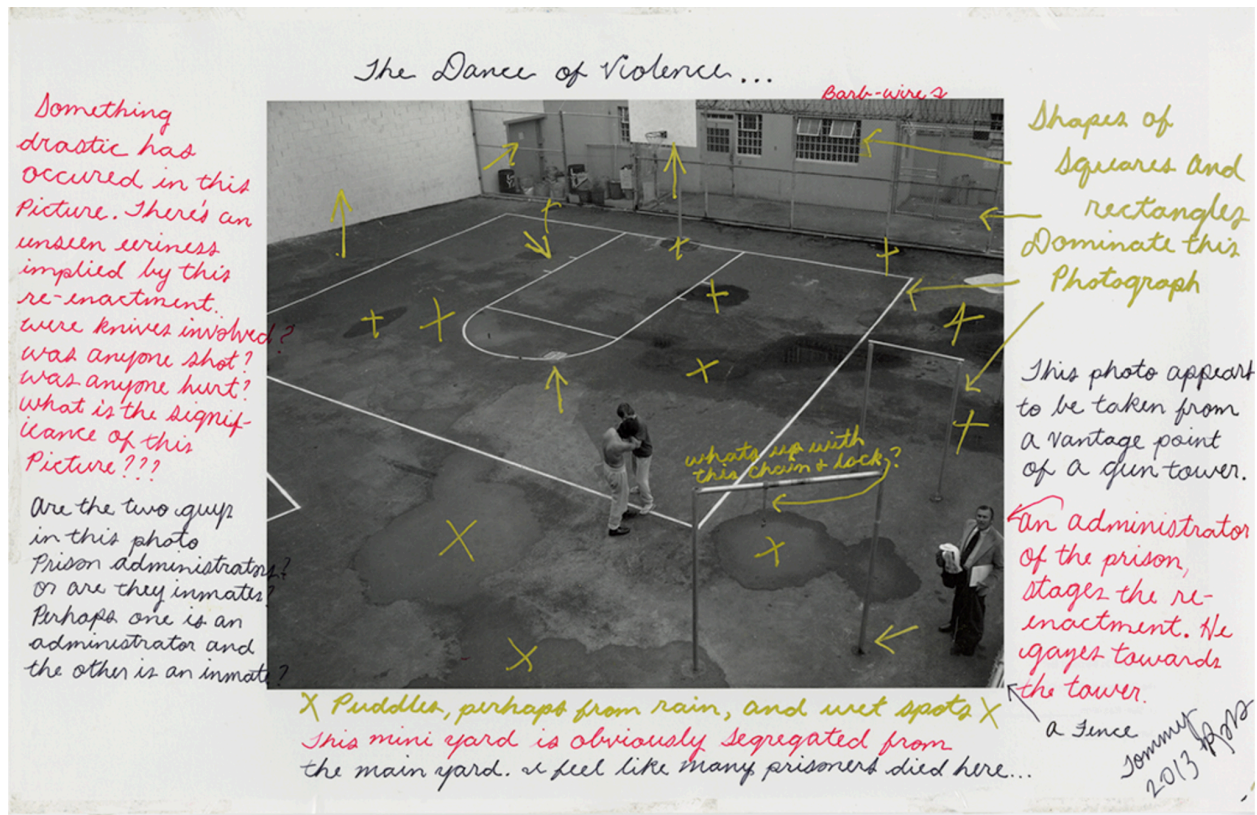
Overview

These exercises help participants analyze how stories are told about people in media, and create visual responses rooted in their own experience.

Contents

- Image Relabelling
- Photovoice

Activity: Image Re-labelling (after Nigel Poor)



Re-Creation 1.6.75 by Tommy Shakur Ross (2013); From Nigel Poor's *San Quentin Part 2*

The goal of this activity is to analyze evocative or ambiguous images taken from popular media in different ways, to use as prompts for discussion. It can facilitate media analysis, to understand and critique how media conveys messages that support negative stereotypes; or to prompt discussion of participants' lived experience.

Prompts for marking up images:

- What do you see? Analyze color and shapes; do any predominate? Are there any patterns?
- What is the backstory of this image? What has occurred up until this moment? Mark previous stages of the story.
- Who is here and what are they doing?
- What are the power relationships in this image? Mark people's relation to other people, objects, buildings, landscape.
- What is unseen vs what is unseen? Is anything implied but not shown?
- Who might have taken this image, from what point of view?
- What might happen next? Mark potential future stages of the story.

Optionally, participants can analyze images inspired by different ways of seeing, such as:

- as a crime scene to be studied, marking forensics that reveal its undisclosed story;
- as reconnaissance of a landscape, analyzing and marking its sight lines, movement vectors;
- as a film studies student mapping power, intent and aesthetic choices in a staged visual composition.

Discuss:

- Does this relate to anything in your life in any way, or anyone you know?

Facilitators Note:

- Choose images drawn from media related to themes, power structures or social phenomena your group is discussing. Eg: stills from military recruitment advertisements were used in workshops with incarcerated veterans. In between moments, or images that might have multiple interpretations work well.
- Example Images from the film [*Is This England? British Poverty in the '90s*](#) and the TV series *Top Boy* can be found [here](#) (see reference section for citations).
- This activity is based on Nigel Poor's San Quentin project. Printing and showing *San Quentin Project #2, Archive Mapping*, can be helpful to model the activity. More information and amazing visual examples of Poor's work can be found [here](#).

Activity: Photovoice

Overview

Photovoice is a participatory visual method in which a group defines a question about an issue affecting their community, takes photographs in response, and uses those images to prompt discussion. The process supports participants in reflecting on lived experience, identifying issues they want to change, and exploring possible forms of action. Images may also be shared through exhibition, publication, or other forms of public engagement.

Background

Photography can express nuance and poetics concerning people's lived experience that might otherwise be difficult to articulate in words. It allows participants to document their realities and present them on their own terms. For example, Paolo Freire asked children in a Brazilian favela to take photos based on the theme of exploitation. One child photographed a nail in a wall, which revealed a system in which shopkeepers rented nails to children so they could hang heavy shoe-shine kits instead of carrying them home. The image opened up a deeper conversation about everyday forms of exploitation that might otherwise remain unseen.

Facilitator Notes

Photovoice can be conducted over multiple sessions or adapted into a shorter format.

- Multi-session format:
 - Session 1: define the theme, guiding question, and process
 - Between sessions: participants take photographs
 - Session 2: view, analyze, and discuss images
 - Session 3: identify next steps (action, exhibition, documentation)
- Short format (approx. 90 minutes):
 - Define a guiding question
 - 30 minutes: participants take photos (e.g., on phones)
 - Return to upload and discuss images using a shared platform (e.g., Miro, Mural)

Be attentive to consent, especially if images include other people or are shared publicly.

Process

1. Co-define the issue you'd like to address as a group
 - What is the question you would like to explore?
 - What kind of general change or action would you like to see as a result?
2. Create your guiding question
 - Be personal (include the word 'you')
 - Focus on one issue
 - Determine a good scope: questions should be relatively specific, allowing for more than one answer, but not too broad
 - Example potentially broad: *What are the qualities of a university that "centers gender and sexuality?"*
 - Example, more personal: *What are the qualities of a space / organization / setting where you have felt your body and identity to be in harmony with the surroundings?*
3. Take Photos
 - Participants take pictures in response to the question that express their perspective
 - Photos can be of anything in any style. They can include people, objects or locations; they can document life, be staged, or be abstract.
 - Depending on the group size and time allotted, each person should take several photos (e.g. 4-8), then pick 1-2 favorites to share for discussion.
 - Optional; participants can write a short written reflection about the image set
4. Discuss (SHMIR method)

Review submitted photos one at a time.

 - See: What do we notice?
 - Happening: What is taking place
 - Meaning: How does the photo create meaning; why do we find it meaningful?
 - Issue: How does it relate to the issue we are discussing?
 - Response: Does the photo or discussion point to anything we might do in Response?

Participants may share their intentions if they choose.

5. Synthesize

- Identify key themes, patterns or shared experiences
- Consider whether anything in the discussion points to ideas for action, design prototypes, pilots, storytelling or creative experiments?

6. Disseminate (optional)

If sharing the work in any form

You're encouraged to use all images from the main discussion that participants consent to share; it's possible to use full names, initials, or remain anonymous

- Consider formats - zine, exhibition, online, public presentation.
- Ask: whose voice is being centered? How is dissemination giving participants voice?
- Who needs to hear the message? Why?

7. Reflect

- What stood out?
- What worked or could be improved?
- What felt meaningful or enjoyable through this process?

Please see the References section in the Appendix for resources on Photovoice.

Participatory Futuring and Worldbuilding

Overview

These exercises support participants in imagining alternative futures, experimenting with possibility, and linking future vision to present action.

Contents

- [Backcasting](#) - participants collectively imagine designs from a functioning future, to see if any might inspire things to be built in the present
- [Worldbuilding](#) - imagines the logic of a future society in which to potentially model change
- [Futures Cone](#) - facilitates imagining oneself positively existing in the future

Activity: Backcasting (Collective Imagining)

Based on the futuring exercise *Prescriptions for Just Communities* developed by Melanie Crean with Ayodamola Okunseinde, this activity invites participants to imagine a future, roughly 10-15

years from now, where a specific social problem has been resolved. Rather than focusing on how the problem was solved, participants envision what systems, technologies, services, or designs now exist that allow this new society to function in healthy and just ways. What would that society look like? What structures or mindsets would need to exist to support it?

Example prompts:

- Imagine a future where transitions from incarceration or military service to civilian life happen seamlessly.
- Imagine a world without prisons, where communities are both safe and just.

Why Design for the Future?

Designing for the future activates a different mode of thinking than reacting only to present-day problems. Rather than working incrementally within current limits, this method begins with a desirable outcome and works backward - asking what steps might be taken now to make that vision possible. This reframing helps break out of limiting frameworks and opens up space for more transformative ideas.

A “wicked problem,” such as climate change or racial injustice, is something so complex that it has no singular solution. They require many responses, created from different perspectives, at different scales, in different forms. Designers often begin by creating functional interventions that help shift perspective and reorient people, systems, or institutions, disrupting familiar assumptions to enable new understanding.

Preparation

- The group decides on a problem it would like to address.
- Consider a future ~10-15 years from now in which that problem no longer exists.
- There’s no need to explain how the issue was resolved. Instead, focus on what allows this future society to function well.
- Break into groups of 2-3, give each paper, something to draw with, and three card prompts, one from each category:
 - Social or emotional mindset (e.g., transformation, stability, hope)
 - Subject domain (e.g., education, wellness, justice, fashion)
 - Design attribute (e.g., spherical, intelligent, motorized)

Ideation

- Using the prompts, participants imagine a new design, service, or object that helps their future society function. What systems, services, technologies, or cultural norms would need to be in place?
- Each group writes down their prompts, sketches the concept, gives it a name, and writes a short explanation.

Example: The combination of transformative, wellness, and artificial intelligence led to a design that reuses predictive policing data to power “predictive care,” anticipatory support that interrupts pathways into incarceration.

Group Discussion

- What design decisions did each group make, and why?
- What needs or values does each design address?
- How could elements of these concepts be prototyped today?
- What challenges might arise in implementation, and how could they be overcome?

Activity: Worldbuilding

Overview

Worldbuilding is a creative method for imagining alternative ways of being through storytelling. By constructing a fictional or speculative world, participants can explore how systems, relationships, and power structures operate, and consider how they might be transformed. This process helps people to experiment with creating new social possibilities and to consider their potential impact before taking action in real-world contexts.

Background

Worldbuilding draws on the idea that the stories we inherit shape how we understand reality. As N.K. Jemisin suggests, stories help us make sense of the world, helping us structure both personal and collective memory, and influence what we perceive as possible or “normal.” By examining how worlds are constructed in fiction—through environment, culture, and power—we can better recognize how similar dynamics operate in society.

Understanding that systems are designed is essential to imagining how they might be dismantled, redesigned or transformed. The more clearly we understand the interrelation of cultural elements and systems of power, the more effectively we can intervene, both in imagined and lived worlds. Worldbuilding therefore becomes a method for analyzing power, imagining alternatives, and giving form to values, identities, and strategies of resistance.

Process

1. Geography, Climate & Ecology

Begin by imagining a world as an interconnected system, where landscapes, climates, and life forms shape each other.

- What is the terrain: mountains, forests, oceans, deserts, ruins?
- What natural resources exist, and how are they harvested, used or protected?
- What's the climate and how does it affect daily life?
- Are there recurring natural events (floods, droughts, storms)?
- What forms of life exist: human, animal, vegetal, technological, hybrid?
- How do these beings sustain or disrupt the ecosystem?

2. Culture & Belief Systems

Create at least two distinct cultures that coexist in this world.

- What values, beliefs or taboos shape each culture?
- What rituals, symbols, or practices define daily life?
- How are identity and belonging expressed?
- How is knowledge created, shared or controlled?
- How do their histories or cosmologies shape how they see the world?
- How does geography and environment influence culture (e.g., scarcity of water, abundance of wind)?

3. Power & Conflict

Consider how power operates.

- Who or what holds power (institutions, technologies, groups)?
- What conflicts exist (social, political, economic, environmental, philosophical)?
- How are roles, resources, or opportunities distributed?
- What privileges or constraints are attached to different positions?
- What is defined as normal? How is this expressed?
- What stories or myths support or resist dominant power structures?

4. Characters & Perspective

Create at least two characters in this world.

- What are their backgrounds, goals and relationships?
- How do they navigate, benefit from, struggle with or challenge the world's systems?
- What do they hope to protect, change or survive?
- How does your own lived experience and perspective relate to the world?

5. Ritual & Reflection

- Create a ritual, tradition or event that reveals a core belief, value or quality of the world (celebration mourning ritual, rite of passage).
- What does this tradition reveal about power, belonging, resistance, or joy?

6. Reflection

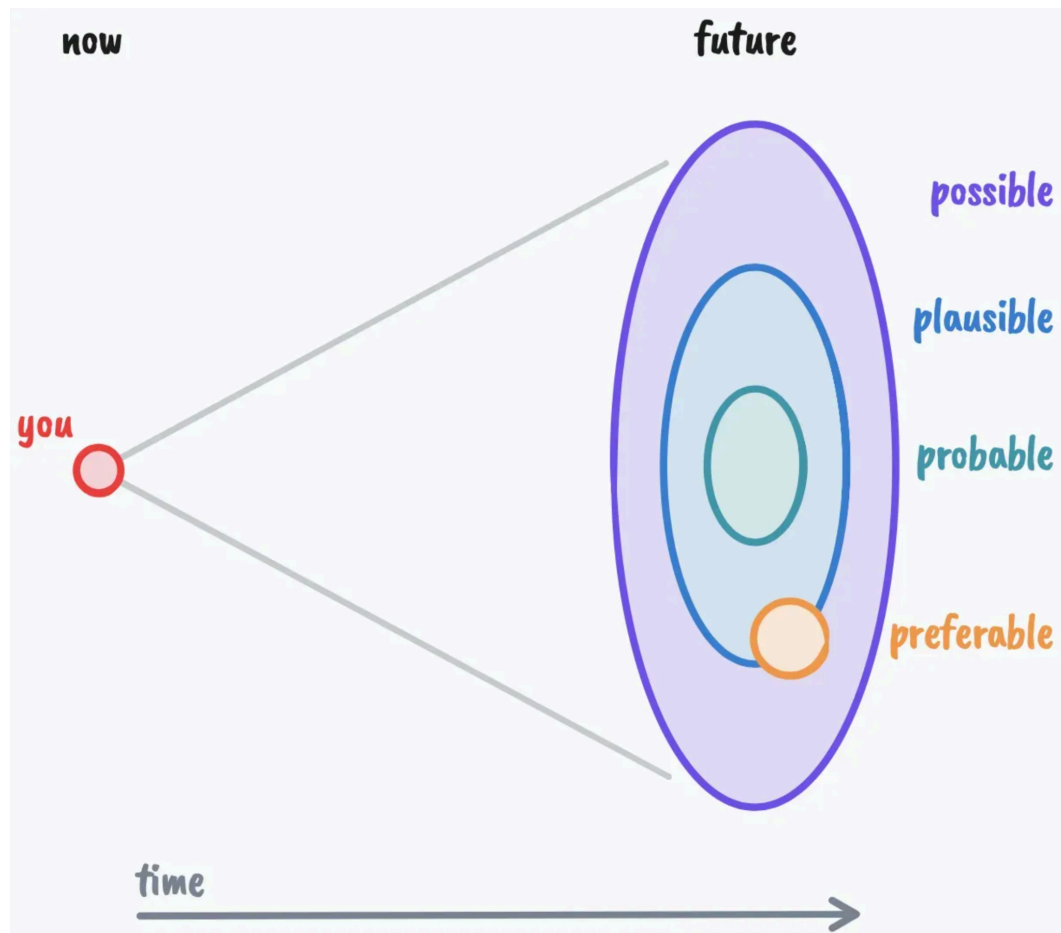
- How does your own lived experience shape how you have constructed this world, or interpret its meaning?
- Are there aspects of this world that could be explored, adapted or prototyped in real life?

Activity: Futures Cone

Adapted from an exercise by [Ashley Jane Lewis](#) based on Stuart Candy's Future Cone.

Overview

This exercise guides participants in imagining themselves three to five years into the future. Using a Futures Cone diagram, they explore what is probable, plausible, possible, and preferable in their own future development.



From *Cybernetic Futures Explained* <https://benswift.me/blog/2022/01/20/cybernetic-futures-explained>

Background: The Future Cone is a tool for imagining multiple potential futures:

- Probable: What is likely to happen based on current trajectories.
- Plausible: What could realistically happen, even if less likely.
- Possible: What might happen, including unexpected ideas.
- Preferable: The most compelling, meaningful outcomes - your desired future.

Example: In chair design

- Probable: Slightly more sustainable versions of today's chairs.
- Plausible: Fully biodegradable, zero-waste chairs.
- Possible: Hovering chairs or AI-integrated adaptive seats.
- Preferable: Designs aligned with personal values and long-term ecological goals.

Instructions

Set up

- Draw a small circle on the left labeled “You” or “Now”
- Draw a larger circle on the right labeled with a future year
- Connect the top and bottom of the circles to form a horizontal cone

Step 1: Plot the Probable

Inside the center of the large circle, write down 2–3 things you are likely to be doing in a few years, based on current work or ongoing projects.

Step 2: Imagine the Possible

Around the outer edge of the large circle, list 8–20 “Possibles”:

- Tools, practices, or mediums you want to explore.
- Collaborations, residencies, or fields of study you’re curious about.
- Ambitions like publishing a book, hosting a podcast, creating a curriculum, or organizing a community archive.

Prompting questions:

- What do you want to be known for?
- What conversations do you want to be part of?
- Where would you like your work being shown, taught, or used?
- In what field, method or genre does your name come up?

Step 3: Identify the Plausible

Draw a middle ring inside the large circle.

- Choose 3–5 items from the “Possible” list that feel realistic over the next 1–2 years.
- These might include projects you’re equipped to begin soon, or opportunities you’re close to accessing.

Step 4: Define the Preferable

- Circle 1–2 items from the Plausible ring that feel most exciting, meaningful, or aligned with your values.
- These become your guiding star, a preferred future you want to work toward. These can inform future goals, even beyond school or immediate obligations.

Facilitators’ Notes

Encourage participants to reflect on:

- What future work feels most meaningful?
- What forms or themes feel resonant?
- What kind of community or context do participants want to be part of?
- What do they want to be recognized for?

Optional Add-On: Core Values as Stories

Invite participants to describe a personal story that reflects what drives their decisions. Distill two or three core values from that story and use them to anchor the Futures Cone.

Appendix

Appendix

Ice Breakers

Icebreakers are short activities designed to warm up a group, encourage participation, and foster genuine connections before diving into a workshop, meeting or class. The co-facilitator(s) should model the activity first, especially when asking for participation that leans on sharing personal stories.

1. Walking circle

a. Directions

This is a great icebreaker for activating a space. Share you will share a prompt and then change it up. The facilitator(s) may need to do an assessment of the mobility of participants, and adjust the prompt from walk to move (etc.). Walk like you are carefree . . . walk like a professor, walk like a new student at the university . . . like a tourist in NYC . . . , like an Olympian . . . like you're happy, etc.

2. Zip, Zap, Zop

a. Directions

Stand in a circle. Someone begins by pointing to another person in the circle and saying "ZIP!" That person then points to yet another person and says "ZAP!" That person points to another person and says "ZOP!" This continues, but the words must be said in order: ZIP, ZAP, ZOP. If someone makes a mistake and says a word out of order, that person is out of the game.

b. Alternatives

Sit in a circle. One person starts by turning to the person (either direction) next to them and saying Zip. The Zip is passed around in the same direction until someone says Zap, which acts as a reverse. The Zoop is used for anyone in the circle, said and directed using eye contact and body language for the other person to pick up and respond with a Zip, Zap, or Zoop!

3. Name Toss

a. Directions

Arrange the group in a circle. One person starts off by saying the name of someone else in the circle, and tossing the ball to them. That person then in turn says "thank you ____" to the person who threw it to them, then says the name of a different person who has not yet received the ball and tosses it to them. That continues until everyone in the circle has received the ball once. Generally, the objective is to pass the ball around the circle without dropping it. If the ball is dropped, the group restarts until completed without dropping.

b. Alternatives

- i. Once the group has accomplished the task as described above, add a second item (ball, rubber chicken, etc.) and instruct the group that it, too, must travel in the same pattern. You can add more items as you see fit. For a more "team-building" type game, add 4-6 items, and hold the rules in place. For a more "ice breaker" type game, add as many items as possible, particularly goofy props, and you will see the group get sillier and sillier. You can slowly take props out after a few minutes and end on one last round of the name toss.
 - ii. Or, one playing the original game, the team must work backwards in the order the ball was tossed
4. Catch a Story (10 minutes)
 - a. Directions

Catch a Story Have a ball or (better) a beanbag. Begin a story. Throw it to the person who must continue the story. This is better than dragging around the circle and shy people can get rid of the story after only one word.
 - b. Alternatives

A variation on this is "fortunately, unfortunately". Each person must add a sentence, changing the sentence of the main character.
5. Banana Slap
 - a. Directions

Everyone is in a circle with their hands out, with one person in the middle holding a banana shaped object (optional). Someone in the circle calls out the name of another person in the circle. The person in the middle tries to slap the hand of the person whose name is called. The person whose name is called tries to call the name of another person in the circle before their hand is slapped.
6. Big Wind Blows
 - a. Directions

Participants pair up and compete in rock, paper, scissors. Whoever wins 2 out of 3 games with the partner is the "winner" of that pair. The loser then becomes the winner's "biggest fan," following around and cheering them on in their matches with others. Each "winner" collects the fans of the person they win against until there are two finalists, each with a group of biggest fans.
7. Biggest Fans
 - a. Directions

Participants pair up and compete in rock, paper, scissors. Whoever wins 2 out of 3 games with the partner is the "winner" of that pair. The loser then becomes the winner's "biggest fan," following around and cheering them on in their matches with others. Each "winner" collects the fans of the person they win against until there are two finalists, each with a group of biggest fans.
8. History of your name

- a. Note: This activity can be triggering for individuals with a history of trauma. Alternatively, instructions can include your 'chosen name or family name.'
- 9. History of your body art
 - a. Directions

Tell the story of a tattoo that you have; or a tattoo that you'd consider getting, even if it might be invisible to others.
- 10. Describe 2-3 words or phrases of slang, that are currently used where you live now, or were used where you grew up.
 - a. Note: Reminding folks of community agreements around types of languages/vocabulary that are part of the setting may need to occur before this activity. For example, use of profanity or words that are derogatory.
- 11. Who are five people, living or dead, who you would invite to a dinner party?
- 12. Describe 1-2 objects that are dear to you, that represent some aspect of your personality.
- 13. Describe a song that is meaningful to you, that you associate with a positive memory. This could be a song you associate with a holiday, from the radio, from time with family or friends.
 - a. If time allows that same day or later in a multiple day workshop or meeting, create a playlist of the songs mentioned.
- 14. If you could have a portrait created of you in any media or style, what would it be?
 - a. Directions

Describe what where you are, what you're wearing, how you are positioned, and any items you might hold or have surrounding you.
- 15. If you've ever received any useful advice, describe it. Or, describe advice you'd give to your younger self.
 - a. Directions

Describe why it was or is useful. You may use a format such as "Dear {name}, you" to activate the advice in the here and now.
- 16. Community Building Activity for workshops with multiple sessions
 - a. Directions

Ask the group: What can we do within each session to facilitate the group connecting with each other?
- 17. To end each session - Summary and Assessment
 - a. Directions

Ask what people learned, what they liked, and especially how they can apply information learned to their lives. Also, ask what they would do differently for that session or day of the workshop or the next day/session.
- 18. ZOOM/Online Icebreakers
 - a. The Chat Waterfall
 - i. Directions

Ask an open-ended question (e.g., *“What’s one thing that made you smile this week?”* or *“Where is your dream travel destination?”* or *“What is your comfort food?”*)

Tell participants to type their answer into the chat box, but do not press Enter yet.

Count down from three and tell everyone to hit send at the same time.

This creates a cascade of answers everyone can read at once.

b. Two-Word Check-in

i. Directions

Ask everyone to think of exactly two words that describe how they are feeling at that moment or how their week is going.

Have participants type their two words into the chat or call on them one by one to unmute and share.

c. Scavenger Hunt

i. Directions

Tell participants that they have 3 minutes to find as many of these things as you can:

Something blue

Something that smells good

Something that you should get rid of

Something that makes you happy

(other options you could ask:

Your fave midnight snack

The last note you wrote yourself (a to-do list, an affirmation, you name it)

The last text you sent to someone

Something that reminds you of someone you love)

Have everyone hold their items up to their camera, ask participants to share a brief story about the object they are sharing. Alternate participation to maximize participation with different folks.

d. Breakout Room Pairings

i. Directions

Use the Zoom Breakout Room feature to place participants into pairs.

Give them a prompt (e.g., *“Tell your partner a favorite childhood memory”* or *“Together, invent an imaginary secret handshake”*).

Set a timer for 3 to 5 minutes, then rotate participants into new pairs for a different prompt.

Grounding Exercises

Grounding exercises are techniques designed to quickly pull you away from anxiety, panic, or flashbacks by reconnecting you to the present moment and your physical surroundings. It can be part of intention setting for a workshop as well as connecting with members of a group.

1. Connecting to the Land and opening grounding activity

a. Directions

The pace is important here. Allow for the movement for both the sitting and breathing.

The facilitator reads or says: “Find a place where you are sitting or can sit comfortably.”

Once folks are sitting: “If you feel okay doing so, close your eyes. If you don’t want to, then just find a place in front of you where you can gently focus—maybe on the table, floor, or the wall across from where you are sitting. Now take four deep breaths. Feel your chest rise and fall as you take in the air and let it out. Each time you breathe in, imagine taking in a calm, peaceful feeling. As you breathe out, let all the stress leave your body. Let your shoulders relax and soften. Let your eyes and face relax and soften. Let all the stress leave your whole body. Feel the connection with our ancestors, the sacredness of the space, and the connection with the land. [You may insert the indigenous name of the land you are in.]

2. Feel your body

a. Purpose: Reconnecting to the body without judgement

b. Directions

You can do this sitting or standing. Focus on how your body feels from head to toe, noticing each part. Consider:

- your hair on your shoulders or forehead
- the weight of your shirt on your shoulders
- whether your arms feel loose or stiff at your sides
- your heartbeat, and whether it’s rapid or steady
- whether your stomach feels full or you feel hungry
- whether your legs are crossed or your feet are resting on the floor
- Curl your fingers and wiggle your toes. Are you barefoot or in shoes?

How does the floor feel against your feet?

3. Sensory Awareness (5-4-3-2-1 Technique)

a. Purpose: brain rapid reset

b. Directions

The facilitator reads the following prompts:

5: Look for 5 things you can see around you (e.g., a chair, a plant, the sky).

4: Focus on 4 things you can touch (e.g., your hair, the desk, the floor).

3: Listen for 3 things you can hear (e.g., traffic, birds, your breath).

2: Identify 2 things you can smell (e.g., soap, air, food).

1: Notice 1 thing you can taste (e.g., toothpaste, coffee)

4. Physical & Tactile Grounding

- a. Purpose: Awareness to your body and its connection to the environment
 - Dig your heels in: Focus on your feet against the ground, noticing the weight.
 - Temperature change: Run cold or warm water over your hands.
 - Clench/Release: Tighten your fists, hold for 5-10 seconds, then release and feel the relaxation.
 - Carry a calming object: Carry a small rock, fabric, or jewelry in your pocket to touch.
 - Stretch: Extend your arms and legs to feel sensations of tension and release.
 - Butterfly tapping: Tap your chest or shoulders gently with your hands, alternating sides.

5. Breathing & Movement

- a. Purpose: Using breath or movement to help regulate the nervous system.
 - Box breathing: Inhale for 4 counts, hold for 4, exhale for 4, pause for 4.
 - Legs-up-the-wall: Lie down with your legs extended up a wall to calm the body.
 - Movement: Stretching, jumping jacks or running in place to bring your focus to the physical sensation of movement.

6. Mental Grounding

- a. Purpose: These techniques challenge the mind to focus, diverting it from stressful thoughts.
 - Category Game: List as many items as possible in a category (e.g., states, bands, foods).
 - Describe your surroundings: Describe your environment in detail (e.g., "The wall is blue, the chair is wooden").
 - Alphabet Game: Pick a topic (e.g., animals) and name one for every letter of the alphabet.
 - Say a calming phrase: Repeat a phrase like "I am safe right now".

7. Soothing Techniques

- a. Purpose: These techniques work best when practiced regularly, allowing you to quickly employ them when needed to manage, for instance, high stress or panic.
 - Use pleasant scents: Light a scented candle or use essential oils. A facilitator may use these in a workshop or session by having them readily available for folks to place on their wrists or behind the ears (pressure points). Assessing smell sensitivities is required prior to activating this technique.
 - Squeeze hug: Wrap your arms tightly around yourself.

8. Loving Kindness Meditation

- a. Purpose: Loving-kindness meditation (also known as Metta) is a mindfulness practice designed to cultivate compassion, warmth, and goodwill.
- b. Directions
 - Facilitator shares with participants these tips:

Place a hand on your heart: If you feel emotional resistance or have trouble feeling the phrases, placing a hand on your chest can help anchor a feeling of warmth.

No "right" way to feel: Don't force the emotion. Simply intending to wish someone well carries the same mental benefits, even if it doesn't feel natural at first

Find a comfortable seat, take a few deep breaths, and slowly repeat the following phrases for each stage of the meditation after the facilitator reads it:
Yourself

"May I be happy. May I be healthy. May I be safe. May I live with ease."

A Loved One

(Think of someone who brings you joy, and offer these wishes to them.)

"May you be happy. May you be healthy. May you be safe. May you live with ease."

A Neutral Person

(Think of someone you see regularly but don't know well, like a barista or coworker, and offer the same wishes.)

A Difficult Person

(Bring to mind someone you struggle with. If it causes too much distress, it is perfectly fine to skip this step for now.)

All Beings

(Expand your circle of compassion to your community, the world, and all living creatures.)

"May all beings everywhere be happy, healthy, and free."

9. Closing groundings

- a. May the sun bring you new energy by day, may the moon softly restore you by night, may the rain wash away your worries, may the breeze blow new strength into your being, may you walk gently through the world and know its beauty all the days of your life.
- b. The following poem can be used to introduce a circle practice or as a way to reaffirm the community gathered in a circle process. It grounds the community in the ancient (indigenous) practice of circles.

Circle Poem by Hehaka Sapa a.k.a Black Elk

You have noticed that everything an Indian does in a circle,
and that is because the Power of the World always works in circles and
everything tries to be round.

In the old days all our power came to us from the sacred hoop of the nation and
so long as the hoop was unbroken the people flourished. The flowering tree was
the living center of the hoop, and the circle of the four quarters nourished it. The
east gave peace and light, the south gave warmth, the west gave rain and the
north with its cold and mighty wind gave strength and endurance. This
knowledge came to us from the outer world with our religion.

Everything the power of the world does is done in a circle.

The sky is round and I have heard that the earth is round like a ball and so are all
the stars. The wind, in its greatest power, whirls.

Birds make their nests in circles, for theirs is the same religion as ours. The sun comes forth and goes down again in a circle. The moon does the same and both are round. Even the seasons form a great circle in their changing and always come back again to where they were.

The life of a man is a circle from childhood to childhood, and so it is in everything where power moves. Our teepees were round like the nests of birds, and these were always set in a circle, the nation's hoop, a nest of many nests, where the Great Spirit meant for us to hatch our children.

- Black Elk, Holy Man of the Oglala Sioux, 1863-1950

After Care

After care for circlekeepers and facilitators of the Compassionate Care Curriculum is essential. We are facilitating community healing processes which may include heavy emotions and trauma. After care includes releasing absorbed trauma, acknowledging that this work is not finite and self care practices that help prevent burnout. After care involves intentional debriefing, structured wellness practices, and establishing safer boundaries to separate your personal well-being from the emotional labor of facilitation. This is a proactive practice of protecting your physical, emotional, and mental energy!

1. Co-Keeper/Facilitator Debriefing

- a. Process the space: Debriefing with the co-keeper has multiple functions including to evaluate the energy of the space, learn from the experience and assess the need for checking in with any participants. This may also include planning for further circles if the group decided to meet again.
- b. Identify triggers: Take time to honestly identify where your personal "buttons" and "triggers" may have been pushed. Ask yourself: *What was a success? What drained me?*
- c. Monitor agreements: Establish a plan for monitoring any commitments or agreements made by the group. There may also be agreements between co-facilitators that are separate from the larger group ones; take time to establish and revisit these as well.

2. Somatic Release & Grounding

- a. Fuel and hydrate: flush stress chemicals: Drink water and engage in light movement to physically reset your nervous system after absorbing intense emotional energy.
- b. Disconnect: Intentionally release anything that isn't yours to carry through physical activities, a hot bath, or time in nature.
- c. Meditate: Use centering, grounding visualizations to return to your 'normal.'

3. Support Systems

- a. Connect to your support systems: Family, friends, spiritual leaders, confidantes - the list is endless and there are no rights or wrongs regarding who are your supports. The important thing is to be intentional about releasing anything that is not yours to carry.
- b. Reach out to peers: Debrief difficult circles with a mentor or peer support group who understands the unique emotional labor of restorative practices.
- c. Follow-up with participants: Check in on any specific participants who found the circle process particularly stressful or upsetting.

4. Boundary Setting

- a. Hold boundaries: Remember that a circle is a community space, not therapy, and the keeper is not a licensed counselor. Let participants know what is your

availability after the CC process; boundary setting may be important for what happens afterwards.

- b. Prioritize your own needs: Dedicate time for regular self-care (adequate sleep, nutrition, and exercise) to sustain yourself for future circles.
- c. Pre-program transition time immediately following a workshop. Avoid jumping right back into deep work or new workshops.

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